Under the terms of the Bull, which bound Spain and Portugal, Bharat fell within the non-Christian territories earmarked for colonisation, enslavement and evangelisation by Portugal. Subsequently, in 1580, the rights of Portugal over Indian territories were assigned to Spain as the latter's sovereignty extended to Portugal. However, since the Protestant Reformation had undermined the authority of the Catholic Church and the Pope, one of the consequences was the revolt of the Dutch against the Spanish, which resulted in the loss of Spain's monopoly over trade in the East, particularly in Java, between 1595 and 1599. Fearing Dutch monopoly over eastern trade, the English East India Company was established. It is clear from this sequence of events that Bharat's colonisation by Europe was not uninfluenced by the Protestant Reformation.

Ostensibly, the Company was incorporated to establish trading posts in Bharat with the permission of the latter's local rulers, and therefore, the Company was not vested with sovereign powers. The Charter of 1600 issued by the British Crown to the Company, which gave the latter a juristic persona and commercial privileges, such as the exclusive right to trade in the territories identified therein, cloaked the Crown with jurisdiction over the Company and its members. The term of the Charter was originally 15 years, which was renewable at the prerogative of the Crown. The idea behind the grant of such exclusive rights to the Company was to equip it to better compete with other European nations without having to face internal competition from Britain. Effectively, the stage was set for a face-off between the English East India Company and the Dutch East Indies Company.[2] The torture and execution of employees of the English Company by the Dutch in 1623 in Java (known as the Amboyna Massacre), along with other factors, resulted in the presence of the English Company being largely limited to Bharat. This, in turn, led to the consolidation of British presence in Bharat over the years—at first it was trading posts, followed by the construction and ownership of forts for the security of the Company's factories and employees.[3]

While it is typically assumed that the Company, as a commercial entity, had no 'civilising' interest in aiding the spread of Christianity in Bharat, there is evidence to suggest the contrary. For instance, in 1614, the Company put in place measures 'for the recruitment of Indians for the propagation of the Gospel among their countrymen and for imparting to these missionaries such education, at the Company's expense, as would